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The Complete Queen's Gambit

Accepted, Declined, Slav, Semi-Slav, sidelines, structures, and plans

COURSE BOOK

38 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

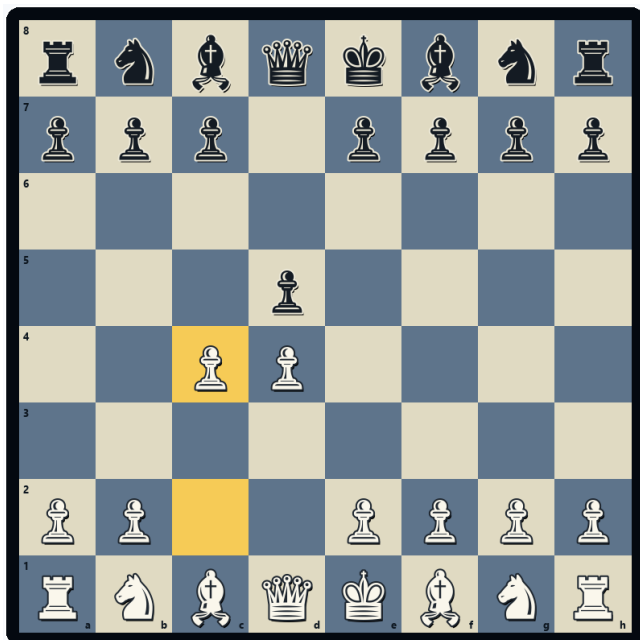
The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

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01. The Queen's Gambit Repertoire Map



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

After d4, d5, and c4, White attacks Black's center with a wing pawn and asks Black to define the structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

Name Black's pawn support or capture.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

E6 means QGD, d takes c4 means QGA, and c6 means Slav.

01. Decision Framework

The Queen's Gambit Repertoire Map

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	After d4, d5, and c4, White attacks Black's center with a wing pawn and asks Black to define the structure.
PIECE JOB	Black takes on c4 and gives White time and central space. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not call every d4 and c4 position a Queen's Gambit after Black chooses a different central system.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Do not call every d4 and c4 position a Queen's Gambit after Black chooses a different central system.

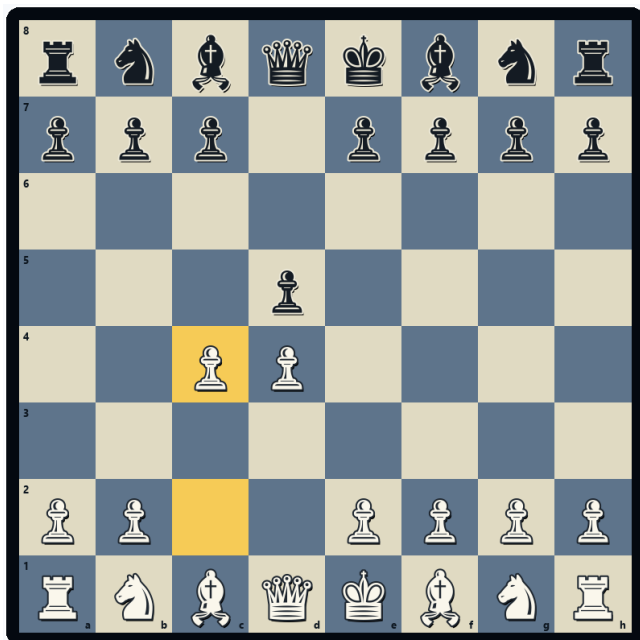
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: E6 means QGD, d takes c4 means QGA, and c6 means Slav.

02. Why the c-Pawn Is Offered



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

The pawn on c4 is offered temporarily to weaken Black's control of d5 and gain time for the center.

PRIMARY PLAN

Did Black protect, capture, or ignore c4?

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

The gambit is about deflecting d5, not donating c4.

02. Decision Framework

Why the c-Pawn Is Offered

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The pawn on c4 is offered temporarily to weaken Black's control of d5 and gain time for the center.
PIECE JOB	Black usually spends time trying to keep an extra wing pawn. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Trying to recover the pawn immediately can waste the development advantage that justified the gambit.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Trying to recover the pawn immediately can waste the development advantage that justified the gambit.

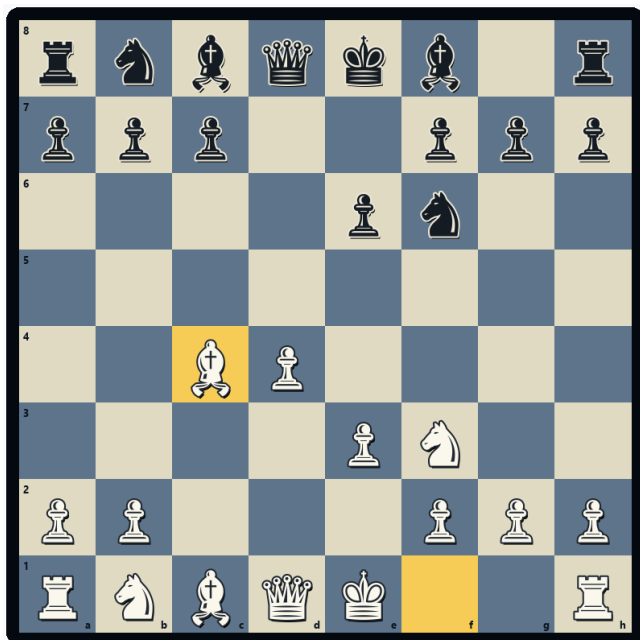
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The gambit is about deflecting d5, not donating c4.

03. How White Recovers the c4 Pawn



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

In the Accepted line, e3 opens the bishop so White recovers c4 while developing naturally.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nf3 and e3 before chasing material.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Nf3, e3, Bxc4: recover the pawn by completing development.

03. Decision Framework

How White Recovers the c4 Pawn

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	In the Accepted line, e3 opens the bishop so White recovers c4 while developing naturally.
PIECE JOB	e3 opens the bishop without weakening the center. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Qa4+ may recover the pawn in some positions, but unnecessary queen moves often help Black develop.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Qa4+ may recover the pawn in some positions, but unnecessary queen moves often help Black develop.

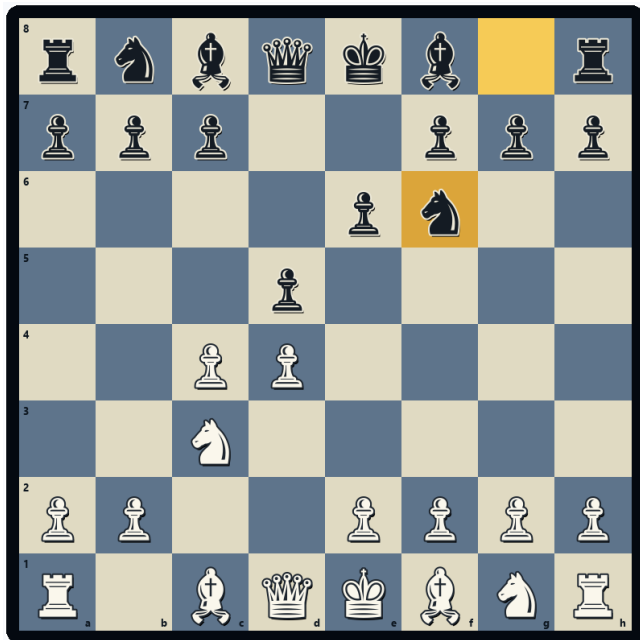
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Nf3, e3, Bxc4: recover the pawn by completing development.

04. Do Not Rush the Central Tension



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

The tension between c4 and d5 preserves options. White can exchange, increase pressure, or wait for Black to clarify.

PRIMARY PLAN

Make useful moves while the tension remains.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6

MEMORY RULE

Tension is stored choice; release it for a reason.

04. Decision Framework

Do Not Rush the Central Tension

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The tension between c4 and d5 preserves options. White can exchange, increase pressure, or wait for Black to clarify.
PIECE JOB	Black's setup reveals which exchange is most useful. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Capturing automatically may give Black an easy recapture and free development.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Capturing automatically may give Black an easy recapture and free development.

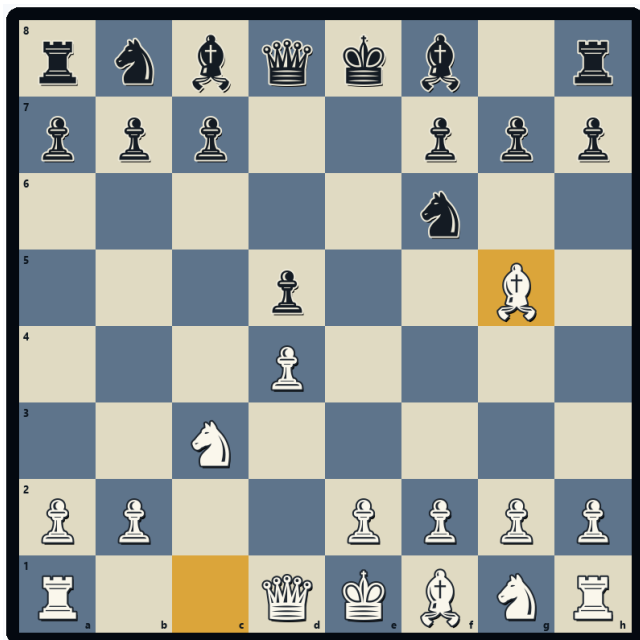
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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Tension is stored choice; release it for a reason.

05. When White Plays cxd5



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

The exchange on d5 creates the Carlsbad structure, where White gains a clear minority attack and central options.

PRIMARY PLAN

Choose cxd5 when you want a stable plan.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5

MEMORY RULE

cxd5 is a doorway into the Carlsbad structure, not a simplification without consequences.

05. Decision Framework

When White Plays cxd5

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The exchange on d5 creates the Carlsbad structure, where White gains a clear minority attack and central options.
PIECE JOB	Bg5 develops before e3 closes the diagonal. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not start a minority attack before the pieces are placed to use the weaknesses it creates.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Do not start a minority attack before the pieces are placed to use the weaknesses it creates.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: cxd5 is a doorway into the Carlsbad structure, not a simplification without consequences.

06. When White Plays dxc5



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

Taking on c5 after Black commits the c-pawn can draw the bishop forward, letting b4 gain space with tempo.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop enough pieces before changing the center.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. a3 a6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. b4 Bd6 9. Bb2 O-O

MEMORY RULE

A central capture is good when the forced recapture helps your development more than Black's.

06. Decision Framework

When White Plays dxc5

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Taking on c5 after Black commits the c-pawn can draw the bishop forward, letting b4 gain space with tempo.
PIECE JOB	b4 attacks the bishop while gaining queenside space. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not exchange merely because the position feels tense; calculate the recapture and resulting structure.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Do not exchange merely because the position feels tense; calculate the recapture and resulting structure.

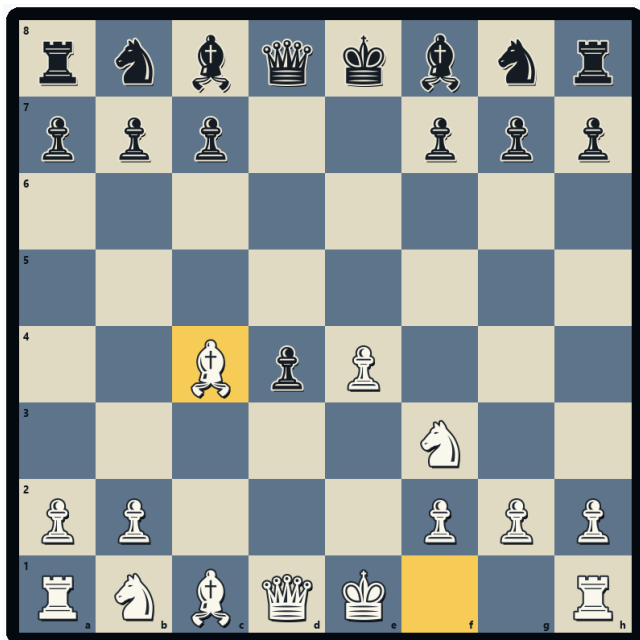
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A central capture is good when the forced recapture helps your development more than Black's.

07. The e4 Break Is White's Dream



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

After Black abandons d5, White often seeks e4 to occupy the center and gain space for rapid development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use e4 when Black cannot undermine it immediately.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. e4 e5 4. Nf3 exd4 5. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

When d5 leaves the center, ask whether e4 can safely replace it.

07. Decision Framework

The e4 Break Is White's Dream

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	After Black abandons d5, White often seeks e4 to occupy the center and gain space for rapid development.
PIECE JOB	Nf3 and Bxc4 bring pieces out with tempo. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	A large center becomes a target if White spends extra moves defending pawns instead of developing.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	A large center becomes a target if White spends extra moves defending pawns instead of developing.

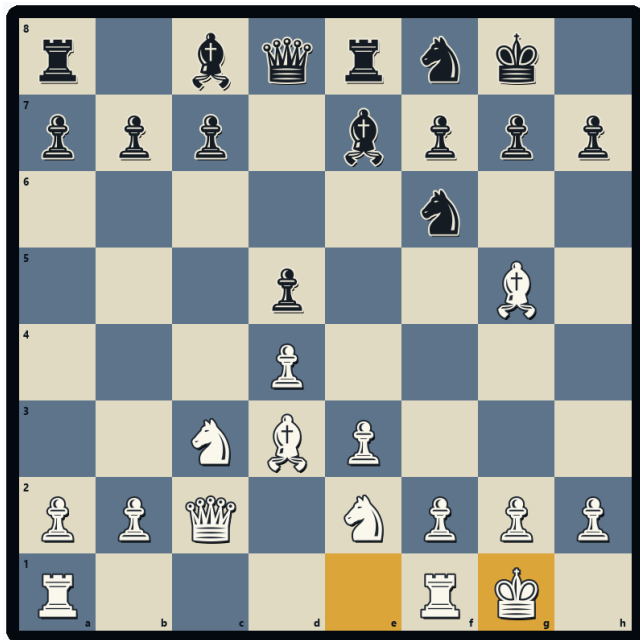
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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When d5 leaves the center, ask whether e4 can safely replace it.

08. The Minority Attack Roadmap



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

In the Carlsbad structure, White advances b4 and b5 to provoke a queenside pawn weakness that can be attacked later.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete the piece setup first.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Prepare, contact, fix, attack: the pawn push creates the target but does not win it by itself.

08. Decision Framework

The Minority Attack Roadmap

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	In the Carlsbad structure, White advances b4 and b5 to provoke a queenside pawn weakness that can be attacked later.
PIECE JOB	b5 challenges c6 and forces a structural decision. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Launching b4 while the center is unstable can allow Black's e5 break to arrive first.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Launching b4 while the center is unstable can allow Black's e5 break to arrive first.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Prepare, contact, fix, attack: the pawn push creates the target but does not win it by itself.

09. Reach the Queen's Gambit Through Nf6



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

When Black begins with Nf6 and e6, White can use Nf3 to allow a Queen's Gambit transposition while avoiding a forced Nimzo-Indian.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify whether Black has committed to d5.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3

MEMORY RULE

Move order changes the available branches, not the identity of the final position.

09. Decision Framework

Reach the Queen's Gambit Through Nf6

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	When Black begins with Nf6 and e6, White can use Nf3 to allow a Queen's Gambit transposition while avoiding a forced Nimzo-Indian.
PIECE JOB	After d5 and Nc3, the position becomes a QGD. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Playing automatic Nc3 against Nf6 and e6 invites Bb4 and a separate Nimzo-Indian repertoire.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Playing automatic Nc3 against Nf6 and e6 invites Bb4 and a separate Nimzo-Indian repertoire.

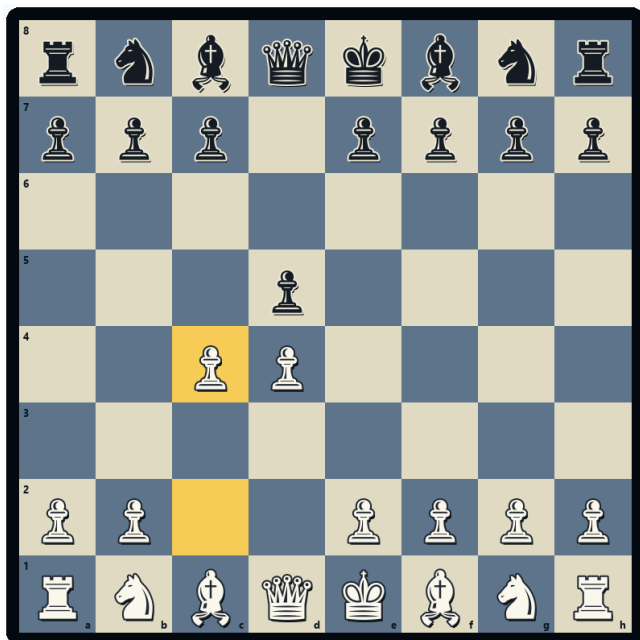
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Move order changes the available branches, not the identity of the final position.

10. How to Train Queen's Gambit Theory



01 - Foundations

READ THE POSITION

Opening theory becomes usable when each move is attached to a position, a purpose, and an opponent resource.

PRIMARY PLAN

Study one short lesson.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

DEFINE: Black chooses a capture, support, or counterbreak that defines the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

Moves fade; positions and purposes survive.

10. Decision Framework

How to Train Queen's Gambit Theory

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Opening theory becomes usable when each move is attached to a position, a purpose, and an opponent resource.
PIECE JOB	Explain why each White move helps the structure. Coordinate it with the central pawn decision.
TACTICAL WARNING	Binge-watching theory produces recognition without recall and feels stronger than it is.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the resulting structure keeps a useful target or active piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the structural lesson of this chapter survives the queen trade.
CLOCK RULE	Binge-watching theory produces recognition without recall and feels stronger than it is.

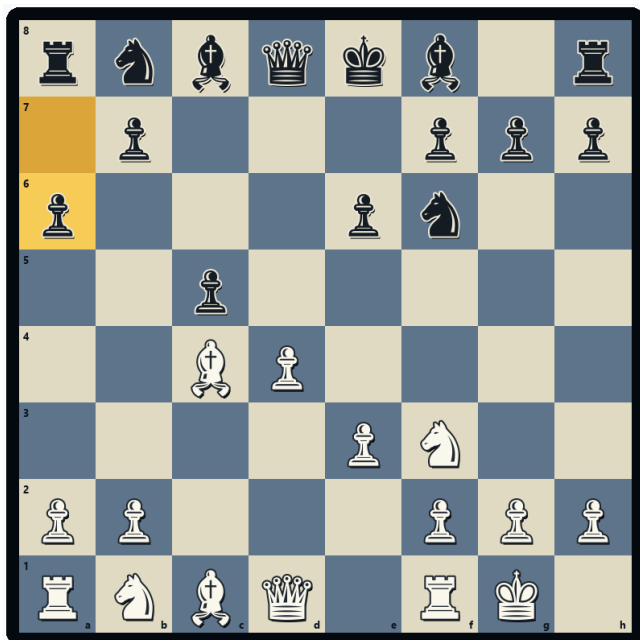
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Moves fade; positions and purposes survive.

11. QGA Classical Main Line



02 - Queen's Gambit Accepted

READ THE POSITION

White regains the pawn through development and reaches the central decision before Black expands with b5.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bxc4 to regain material with development.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black strikes d4 and asks White to define the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4 c5 6. O-O a6

MEMORY RULE

Nf3, e3, Bxc4, castle; only then choose the center.

11. Decision Framework

QGA Classical Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White regains the pawn through development and reaches the central decision before Black expands with b5.
PIECE JOB	The c4 bishop is active but exposed; give it a useful retreat before Black's b5 expansion gains time.
TACTICAL WARNING	Avoid early queen checks unless they win something concrete.
TRADE FILTER	Keep enough active pieces to use White's lead in development; exchanges are welcome only when they leave Black with a passive isolated pawn.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Convert the opening lead by finishing development, occupying open files, and only then attacking a structural weakness. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Avoid early queen checks unless they win something concrete.

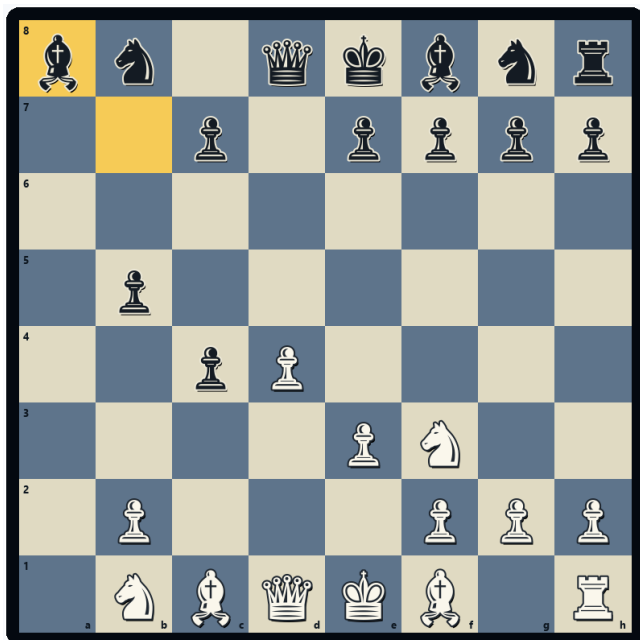
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Nf3, e3, Bxc4, castle; only then choose the center.

12. QGA a6 and b5 Expansion



02 - Queen's Gambit Accepted

READ THE POSITION

Black tries to keep the extra c4 pawn with a6 and b5; White undermines the chain rather than chasing its front.

PRIMARY PLAN

Break the b5 support chain with a4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bb7: Black supports the long diagonal and prepares e6.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 a6 4. e3 b5 5. a4 Bb7 6. axb5 axb5 7. Rxa8 Bxa8

MEMORY RULE

When Black holds c4 with b5, attack b5 with a4.

12. Decision Framework

QGA a6 and b5 Expansion

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black tries to keep the extra c4 pawn with a6 and b5; White undermines the chain rather than chasing its front.
PIECE JOB	White's a-rook and light bishop become useful through the open a-file and the weakened queenside diagonals.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not attack c4 repeatedly while b5 holds it.
TRADE FILTER	Rxa8 is a structural exchange of rooks, not an exchange sacrifice or a trick that wins material, because Black's bishop recaptures.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Turn Black's pawn-holding tempi into faster development and pressure before the queenside pieces untangle. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not attack c4 repeatedly while b5 holds it.

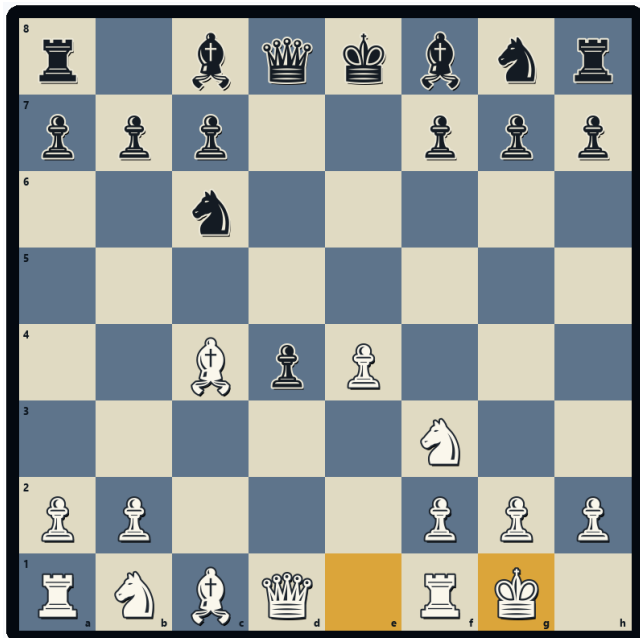
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: When Black holds c4 with b5, attack b5 with a4.

13. QGA 3.e4 Central Variation



02 - Queen's Gambit Accepted

READ THE POSITION

White immediately builds a broad center, accepting that accurate development is needed to justify the space.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the center to gain time for Nf3, Bxc4, and castling.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...e5: Black attacks the center before White consolidates.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. e4 e5 4. Nf3 exd4 5. Bxc4 Nc6 6. O-O

MEMORY RULE

The 3.e4 line is center plus speed: develop before the center becomes a target.

13. Decision Framework

QGA 3.e4 Central Variation

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White immediately builds a broad center, accepting that accurate development is needed to justify the space.
PIECE JOB	Every White piece should develop behind the broad center with tempo; the center is valuable only while it accelerates the pieces.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not defend every central pawn at the cost of development.
TRADE FILTER	Avoid trading the active bishop or attacking knight merely to save a pawn; activity is the compensation that justifies the setup.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Castle, stabilize d4 and e4, then use the space advantage to restrict Black's pieces or create kingside pressure. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not defend every central pawn at the cost of development.

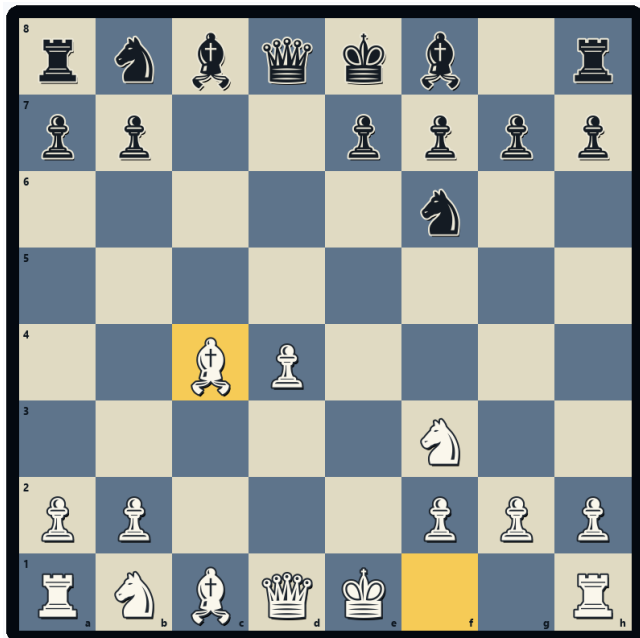
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The 3.e4 line is center plus speed: develop before the center becomes a target.

14. QGA Early c5 and the IQP



02 - Queen's Gambit Accepted

READ THE POSITION

Black challenges d4 immediately, and White accepts an isolated queen's pawn in exchange for open lines and activity.

PRIMARY PLAN

Place pieces on open lines around the isolated pawn.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...e6: Black blockades d5 and attacks the isolated pawn.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 c5 4. e3 cxd4 5. exd4 Nf6 6. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

An IQP buys activity now and becomes a weakness later; use the time.

14. Decision Framework

QGA Early c5 and the IQP

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black challenges d4 immediately, and White accepts an isolated queen's pawn in exchange for open lines and activity.
PIECE JOB	Place pieces on e5, c5 and the open files around the isolated d-pawn instead of assigning every piece to its defense.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not treat the IQP as a weakness from move one.
TRADE FILTER	Keep at least one strong attacking minor piece unless the trade removes Black's best blockader or wins a concrete endgame.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the active phase to create a second weakness before simplifying into a position where d4 needs constant defense. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not treat the IQP as a weakness from move one.

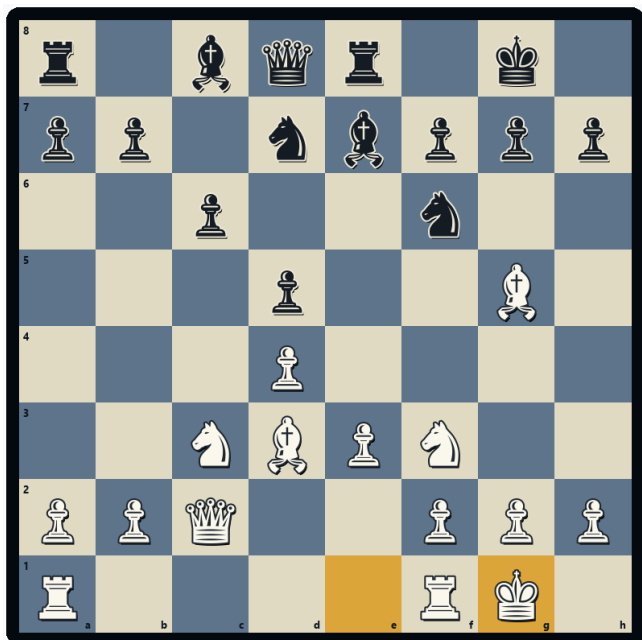
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: An IQP buys activity now and becomes a weakness later; use the time.

15. QGD Exchange with Nf3



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

READ THE POSITION

The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.

PRIMARY PLAN

Prepare a3, Rab1, b4, and b5.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black trades pieces and reduces queenside pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Nf3 means dependable development and a queenside minority plan.

15. Decision Framework

QGD Exchange with Nf3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.
PIECE JOB	The f3-knight supports a reliable center while rooks and queen prepare the queenside files created by b4-b5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the dark-squared bishops when it improves access to c5 and c7; avoid exchanges that relieve all pressure on c6.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Create the c6 weakness with b5, fix it, then transfer pieces to the c-file instead of expecting the pawn push to win by itself. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not launch b4 if Black's central break is faster.

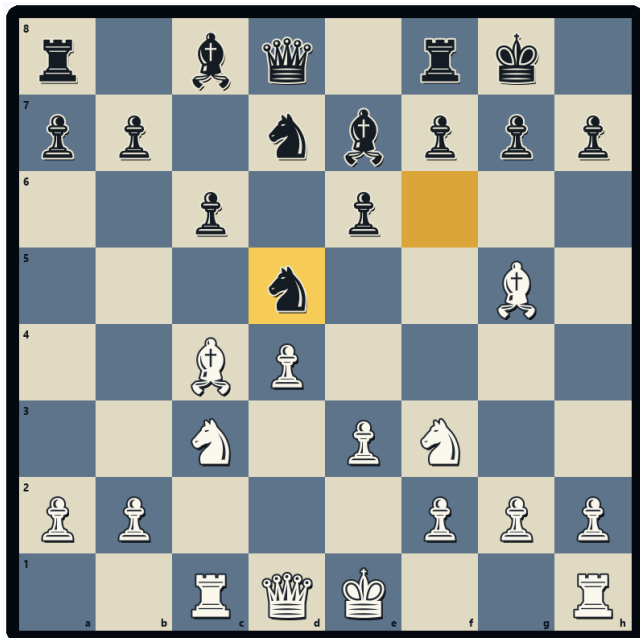
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Nf3 means dependable development and a queenside minority plan.

16. QGD Orthodox Main Line



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

READ THE POSITION

Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use pieces to keep Black's center tied down.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black offers exchanges to relieve space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 Nbd7 7. Rc1 c6 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 Nd5

MEMORY RULE

Orthodox theory is pressure on d5 versus Black's search for c5 and exchanges.

16. Decision Framework

QGD Orthodox Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.
PIECE JOB	White's c1-rook, active c4-bishop and central knights should make Black's cramped pieces pay before exchanges free them.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not retreat automatically when an exchange helps White.
TRADE FILTER	Do not exchange active pieces merely because the position is closed; each trade can release Black's space problem.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Maintain pressure, provoke a concession, and enter the endgame only when a fixed pawn weakness survives the exchanges. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not retreat automatically when an exchange helps White.

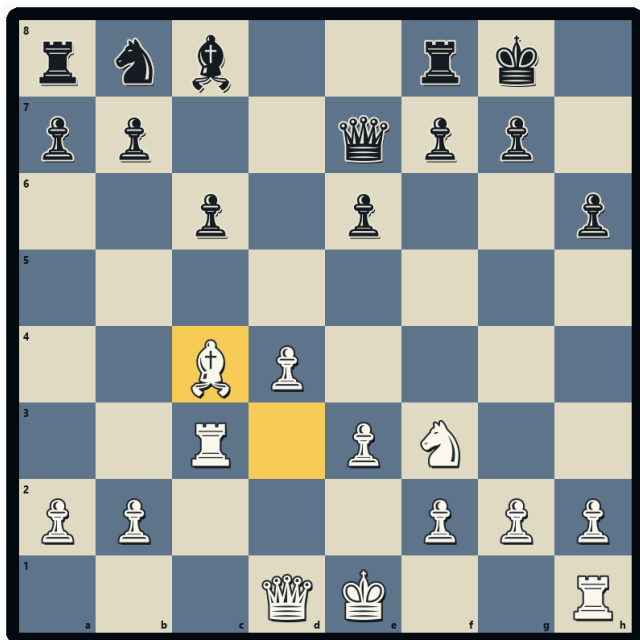
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Orthodox theory is pressure on d5 versus Black's search for c5 and exchanges.

17. QGD Lasker Defense



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

READ THE POSITION

Black uses Ne4 to trade minor pieces and reduce White's space advantage before completing the freeing plan.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the c-file and active bishops after exchanges.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Ne4: Black begins the simplifying operation.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 Ne4 8. Bxe7 Qxe7 9. Rc1 c6 10. Bd3 Nxc3 11. Rxc3 dxc4 12. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Against the Lasker, preserve activity rather than preserving pieces at any cost.

17. Decision Framework

QGD Lasker Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black uses Ne4 to trade minor pieces and reduce White's space advantage before completing the freeing plan.
PIECE JOB	After Black's ...Ne4 exchanges, White's remaining pieces must occupy the open c- and e-files quickly.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not cooperate with every simplification.
TRADE FILTER	Accept simplification when it leaves a queenside weakness or superior minor piece; otherwise preserve tension and space.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Rebuild pressure after the forced trades by centralizing rooks and improving the least active remaining piece. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not cooperate with every simplification.

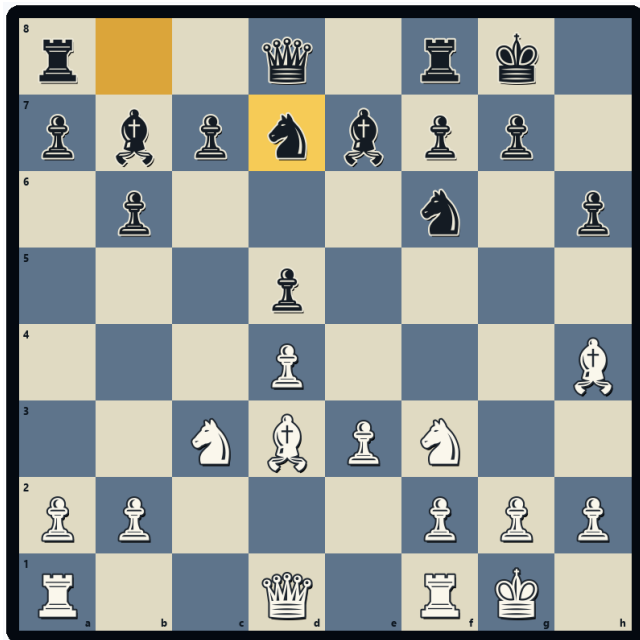
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the Lasker, preserve activity rather than preserving pieces at any cost.

18. QGD Tartakower Defense



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

READ THE POSITION

Black solves the light-bishop problem with b6 and Bb7 while accepting potential queenside dark-square weaknesses.

PRIMARY PLAN

Pressure c7 and queenside entry squares.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...b6-Bb7: Black activates the previously bad bishop.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 b6 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Tartakower: Black frees the bishop with b6; White uses the squares b6 leaves behind.

18. Decision Framework

QGD Tartakower Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black solves the light-bishop problem with b6 and Bb7 while accepting potential queenside dark-square weaknesses.
PIECE JOB	White should pressure the queenside dark squares while preventing Black's b7-bishop from becoming completely free.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not mistake a diagonal for a complete attack.
TRADE FILTER	Trade Black's active bishop when that leaves exploitable light-square or queenside weaknesses, not merely to simplify.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Convert small space and structural edges by restricting the hanging pawns, then attacking them after their activity fades. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not mistake a diagonal for a complete attack.

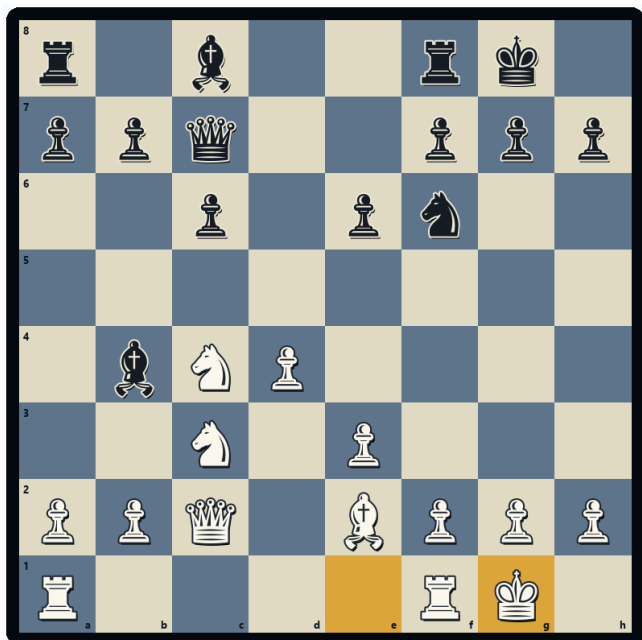
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Tartakower: Black frees the bishop with b6; White uses the squares b6 leaves behind.

19. Cambridge Springs Defense



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

READ THE POSITION

Black develops the queen to a5, pins the c3 knight, and creates tactical pressure before castling.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nd2 and Qc2 to remove tactical pressure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Qa5: Black creates the Cambridge Springs pin and pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Nbd7 5. e3 c6 6. Nf3 Qa5 7. Nd2 Bb4 8. Qc2 O-O 9. Be2 dxc4 10. Bxf6 Nxf6 11. Nxc4 Qc7 12. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Cambridge Springs is a pin problem: Nd2, Qc2, Be2; unpin before recovering c4.

19. Decision Framework

Cambridge Springs Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops the queen to a5, pins the c3 knight, and creates tactical pressure before castling.
PIECE JOB	Nd2, Qc2 and Be2 form a safety net that unpins the queenside before White tries to recover c4.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not chase c4 while the c3 pin remains.
TRADE FILTER	Bxf6 is useful when it removes a tactical defender and permits Nxc4; the order matters more than the desire to keep bishops.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Neutralize the pins, recover the pawn with a developed piece, castle, and only then look for an advantage. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not chase c4 while the c3 pin remains.

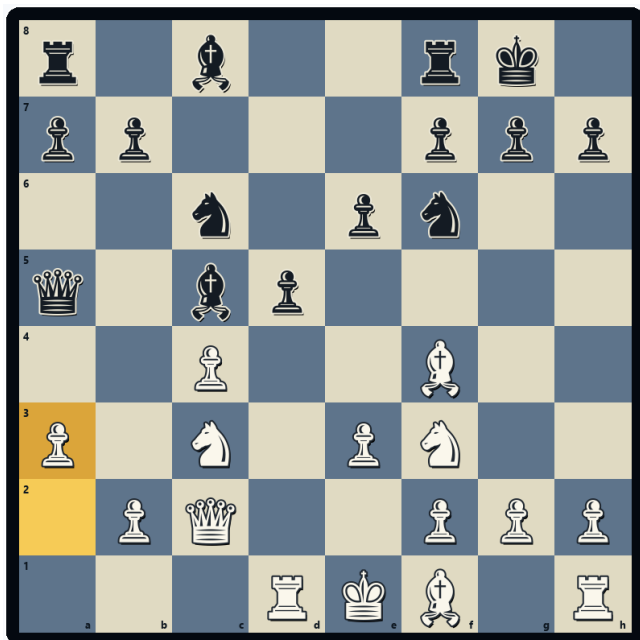
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Cambridge Springs is a pin problem: Nd2, Qc2, Be2; unpin before recovering c4.

20. QGD Harrwitz Bf4 System



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

READ THE POSITION

White develops the bishop to f4, keeps more pieces on the board, and meets Black's central break with active development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete Qc2, Rd1, and a3 with pressure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black challenges d4 and seeks equality.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 c5 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. Qc2 Nc6 9. Rd1 Qa5 10. a3

MEMORY RULE

Bf4 keeps pieces active; Qc2 and Rd1 make the central pressure concrete.

20. Decision Framework

QGD Harrwitz Bf4 System

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White develops the bishop to f4, keeps more pieces on the board, and meets Black's central break with active development.
PIECE JOB	The f4-bishop controls e5 and helps White develop pressure without committing to the traditional Bg5 pin.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not preserve Bf4 if an exchange improves the position.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange the f4-bishop only when the remaining structure or open file compensates for losing its central influence.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use Qc2, Rd1 and a3 to finish development, then turn control of e5 and the d-file into concrete pressure. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not preserve Bf4 if an exchange improves the position.

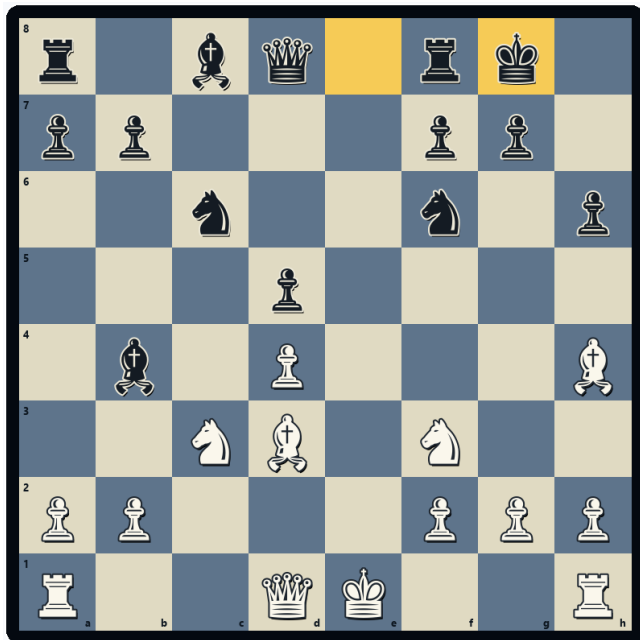
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Bf4 keeps pieces active; Qc2 and Rd1 make the central pressure concrete.

21. Ragozin Exchange Structure



04 - Ragozin and Vienna

READ THE POSITION

Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use development and rooks to prepare the central break.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black attacks d4 and activates the queenside.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 c5 8. e3 Nc6 9. Bd3 cxd4 10. exd4 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Ragozin Exchange means Carlsbad structure plus immediate pressure on c3 and d4.

21. Decision Framework

Ragozin Exchange Structure

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.
PIECE JOB	The pinned c3-knight changes the value of e4 and d5, so White's bishops and queen must carry more central responsibility.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the b4-bishop when it removes the pin on favorable terms, but do not spend tempi forcing an exchange that helps development.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Stabilize d4, castle and place rooks centrally before expanding; the Ragozin demands activity earlier than a quiet Carlsbad. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.

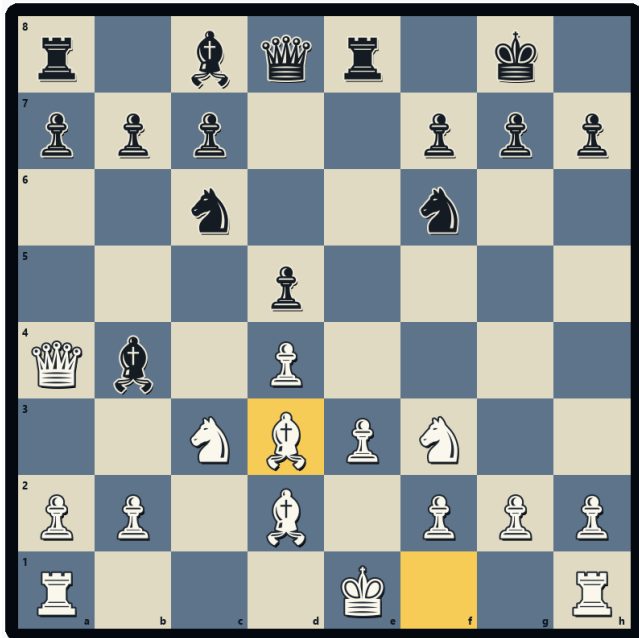
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Ragozin Exchange means Carlsbad structure plus immediate pressure on c3 and d4.

22. Ragozin Qa4 Check



04 - Ragozin and Vienna

READ THE POSITION

Qa4+ questions the pin immediately and encourages Black to commit the queenside knight before White chooses the structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bd2 and a3 ideas to improve while challenging Bb4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nc6: Black blocks the check and increases d4 pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. Qa4+ Nc6 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd2 Re8 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Qa4+ is useful when the information gained is worth the queen move.

22. Decision Framework

Ragozin Qa4 Check

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Qa4+ questions the pin immediately and encourages Black to commit the queenside knight before White chooses the structure.
PIECE JOB	Qa4+ gains information, while Bd2 and Bd3 complete development without letting the queen become the center of attention.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not spend several moves trying to trap the b4 bishop.
TRADE FILTER	A bishop trade on b4 is useful when it improves development or pawn structure; avoid chasing the bishop for its own sake.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the information gained by Qa4+ to choose the structure, then centralize the rooks and stop moving the queen repeatedly. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not spend several moves trying to trap the b4 bishop.

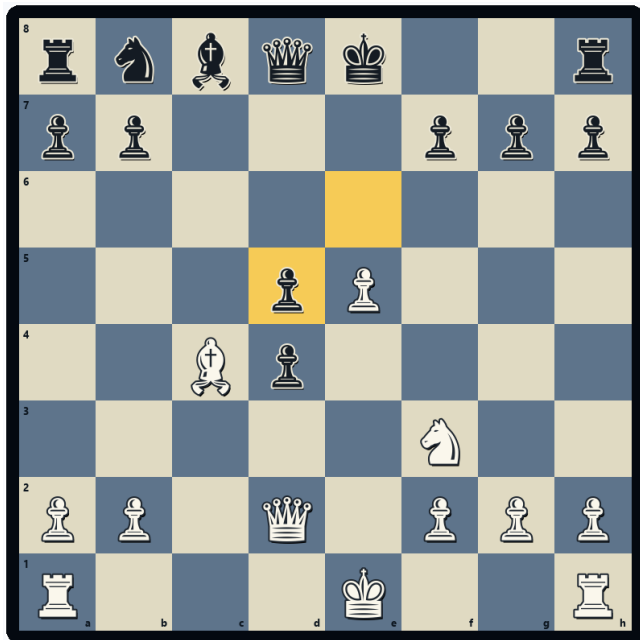
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Qa4+ is useful when the information gained is worth the queen move.

23. Vienna Variation Central Gambit



04 - Ragozin and Vienna

READ THE POSITION

Black takes c4 and pins the knight; White builds e4-e5 and accepts tactical complications for space and development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop rapidly behind the e5 and d4 center.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bb4: Black pins c3 and attacks the center indirectly.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 dxc4 5. e4 Bb4 6. e5 Nd5 7. Bd2 c5 8. Bxc4 cxd4 9. Nxd5 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 exd5

MEMORY RULE

Vienna theory is center, unpin, development-recover c4 only after those.

23. Decision Framework

Vienna Variation Central Gambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black takes c4 and pins the knight; White builds e4-e5 and accepts tactical complications for space and development.
PIECE JOB	White's central pawns give space, but Bd2 and rapid castling are the pieces' urgent jobs while the c3-knight is pinned.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not play the Vienna without understanding the c3 pin.
TRADE FILTER	Do not trade the pieces defending e4 and d4 without calculating the center; structural damage can be acceptable if open lines remain.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Unpin, recover c4 when safe, open lines, and secure the king before trying to exploit the space advantage. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not play the Vienna without understanding the c3 pin.

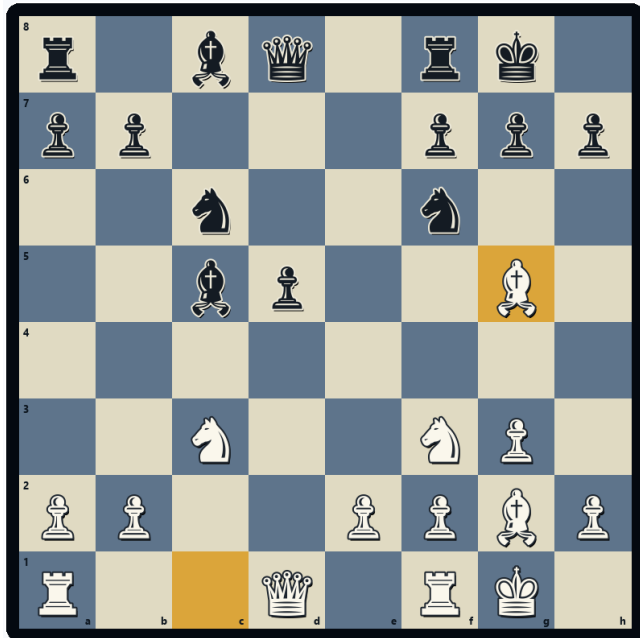
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Vienna theory is center, unpin, development-recover c4 only after those.

24. Tarrasch Defense Main Line



05 - Tarrasch Systems

READ THE POSITION

Black accepts an isolated d-pawn for free development; White uses the fianchetto to pressure the center and reduce Black's activity.

PRIMARY PLAN

Control d4 and place a piece in front of the isolated pawn.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nc6: Black supports d4 and active development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. g3 Nf6 7. Bg2 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. dxc5 Bxc5 10. Bg5

MEMORY RULE

Against the Tarrasch, reduce activity first; the isolated pawn weakens later.

24. Decision Framework

Tarrasch Defense Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black accepts an isolated d-pawn for free development; White uses the fianchetto to pressure the center and reduce Black's activity.
PIECE JOB	White's g2-bishop pressures d5 while the other pieces blockade and attack Black's isolated queen's pawn.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not attack d5 with every piece while Black attacks your king.
TRADE FILTER	Trade active Black pieces-especially those supporting d4 or e4-but keep enough pieces to attack the isolated pawn.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Blockade first, exchange attackers second, then convert the fixed d-pawn or superior minor-piece endgame. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not attack d5 with every piece while Black attacks your king.

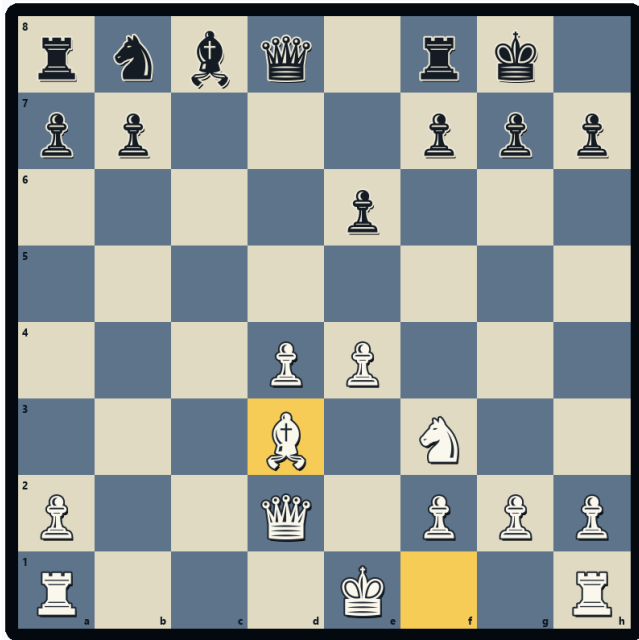
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the Tarrasch, reduce activity first; the isolated pawn weakens later.

25. Semi-Tarrasch Main Line



05 - Tarrasch Systems

READ THE POSITION

Black recaptures on d5 with a knight, and the forcing exchanges give White a broad center and open bishop pair.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bd3, O-O, and rooks to support e4 and d4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nxc3: Black damages White's pawn shape but gives the bishop pair.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 c5 5. cxd5 Nxd5 6. e4 Nxc3 7. bxc3 cxd4 8. cxd4 Bb4+ 9. Bd2 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 O-O 11. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Semi-Tarrasch: accept the pawn shape, keep the broad center, use the bishops.

25. Decision Framework

Semi-Tarrasch Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black recaptures on d5 with a knight, and the forcing exchanges give White a broad center and open bishop pair.
PIECE JOB	White's central pawn duo needs quick piece support because Black has open lines and easy development.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not advance e5 before completing development.
TRADE FILTER	Avoid mass exchanges that turn the central majority into a fixed target; trade when the pawn center can advance afterward.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Complete development, use the space to restrict Black, and transform the center before it becomes overextended. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not advance e5 before completing development.

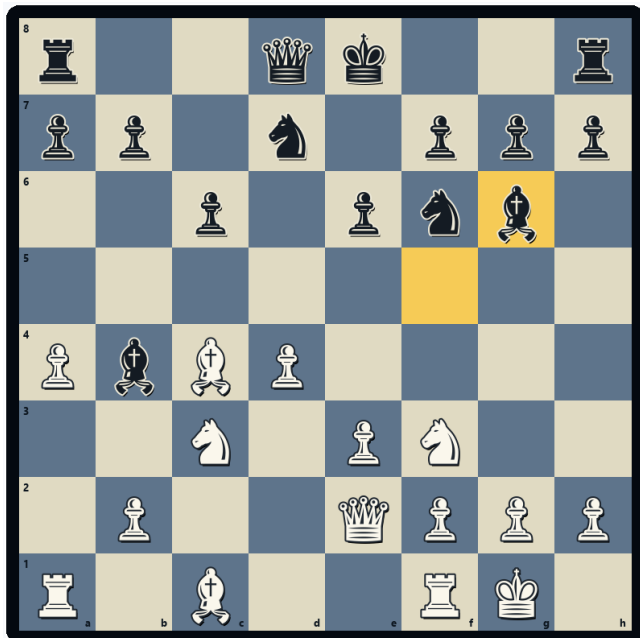
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Semi-Tarrasch: accept the pawn shape, keep the broad center, use the bishops.

26. Slav Main Line with a4



06 - Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

White uses a4 to prevent Black from comfortably holding c4 with b5, then regains the pawn and develops normally.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bxc4 once b5 is prevented.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bf5: Black solves the light-bishop problem before e6.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4 Bb4 8. O-O Nbd7 9. Qe2 Bg6

MEMORY RULE

Against the main Slav, a4 stops b5; e3 and Bxc4 finish the recovery.

26. Decision Framework

Slav Main Line with a4

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White uses a4 to prevent Black from comfortably holding c4 with b5, then regains the pawn and develops normally.
PIECE JOB	a4 prevents comfortable ...b5, while Bxc4 and Qe2 help White complete development without losing control of e4.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not lose development time attacking Bf5 repeatedly.
TRADE FILTER	Bishop exchanges are favorable when they reduce Black's active light-squared play without surrendering control of e4.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Recover c4 through development, castle, and use the space gained by a4 to keep Black's queenside pieces restricted. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not lose development time attacking Bf5 repeatedly.

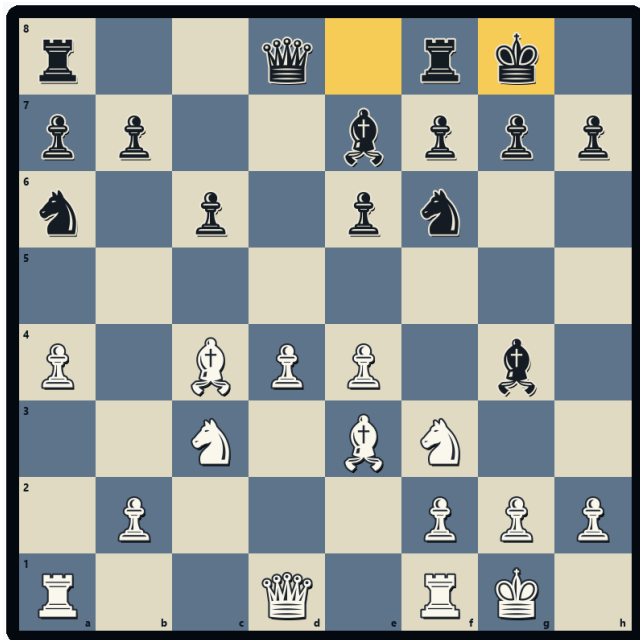
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the main Slav, a4 stops b5; e3 and Bxc4 finish the recovery.

27. Slav Geller Gambit Setup



06 - Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

Against Na6, White uses e4 to occupy the center while Black's knight is offside, creating active piece play for the pawn structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bxc4, O-O, and Be3 behind the broad center.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bg4: Black pins f3 and pressures the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Na6 6. e4 Bg4 7. Bxc4 e6 8. O-O Be7 9. Be3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Na6 gives White time for e4, but only rapid development makes the center strong.

27. Decision Framework

Slav Geller Gambit Setup

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Against Na6, White uses e4 to occupy the center while Black's knight is offside, creating active piece play for the pawn structure.
PIECE JOB	The broad center requires every piece to develop quickly; the a6-knight and g4-bishop are targets only when tempo permits.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push e5 and d5 before pieces are ready.
TRADE FILTER	Material recovery is secondary to keeping active bishops and central control; do not trade them just to regain c4 immediately.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the central space to finish development, castle and force Black's awkward pieces to spend more time reorganizing. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push e5 and d5 before pieces are ready.

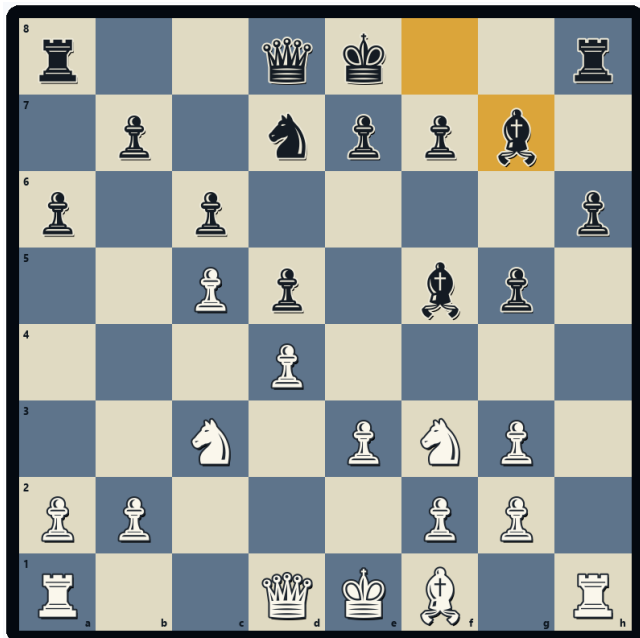
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Na6 gives White time for e4, but only rapid development makes the center strong.

28. Chebanenko Slav with a6



06 - Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

Black prepares b5 with a6; White closes the queenside with c5 and uses the extra space to restrict Black's pieces.

PRIMARY PLAN

Control e5 and b6 so Black lacks a clean break.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...b5: Black expands and attacks the closed chain.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 a6 5. c5 Bf5 6. Bf4 Nbd7 7. e3 Nh5 8. Bg5 h6 9. Bh4 g5 10. Bg3 Nxg3 11. hxg3 Bg7

MEMORY RULE

Chebanenko: c5 gains space; then stop e5 and b6 before maneuvering.

28. Decision Framework

Chebanenko Slav with a6

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black prepares b5 with a6; White closes the queenside with c5 and uses the extra space to restrict Black's pieces.
PIECE JOB	The f4-bishop and c5-pawn gain space, while White must watch that the queenside does not become overextended.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not let the f4 bishop run out of safe squares.
TRADE FILTER	Keep the active f4-bishop unless its exchange creates a lasting weakness; do not retreat it repeatedly without gaining something.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Stabilize c5, complete development and choose the correct central moment before Black undermines the pawn chain. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not let the f4 bishop run out of safe squares.

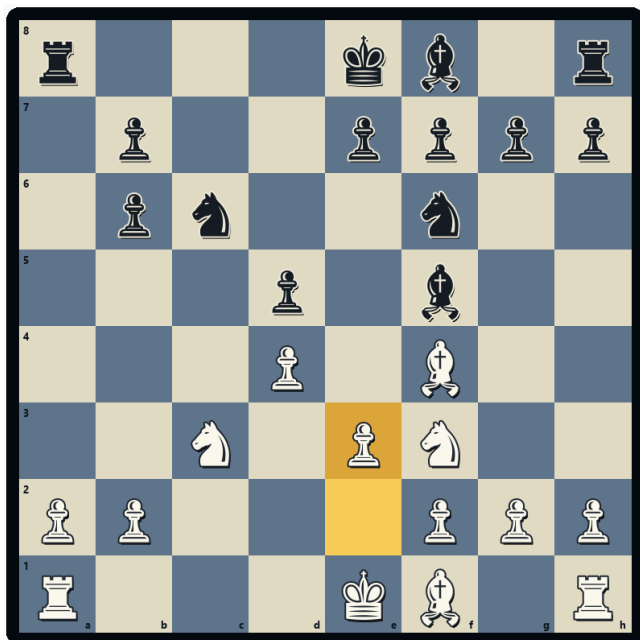
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Chebanenko: c5 gains space; then stop e5 and b6 before maneuvering.

29. Slav 4...Bf5 Pressure Line



06 - Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

Black develops Bf5 before e6; White exchanges the center and uses Qb3 to force structural concessions or queen exchanges.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bf4, e3, and Bb5 to exploit the slight lead.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Qb6: Black defends b7 and offers a queen exchange.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Bf5 5. cxd5 cxd5 6. Qb3 Qb6 7. Qxb6 axb6 8. Bf4 Nc6 9. e3

MEMORY RULE

Against early Bf5, cxd5 and Qb3 turn development time into structural pressure.

29. Decision Framework

Slav 4...Bf5 Pressure Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops Bf5 before e6; White exchanges the center and uses Qb3 to force structural concessions or queen exchanges.
PIECE JOB	Qb3 pressures b7 and d5, while Bf4 develops with tempo toward an endgame where Black's queenside structure matters.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not call b6 weak unless pieces can attack it.
TRADE FILTER	A queen trade on b6 is welcome only when the doubled b-pawns or development lead remains meaningful in the endgame.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use superior development to fix the queenside pawns, then improve the king and rooks before trying to win one. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not call b6 weak unless pieces can attack it.

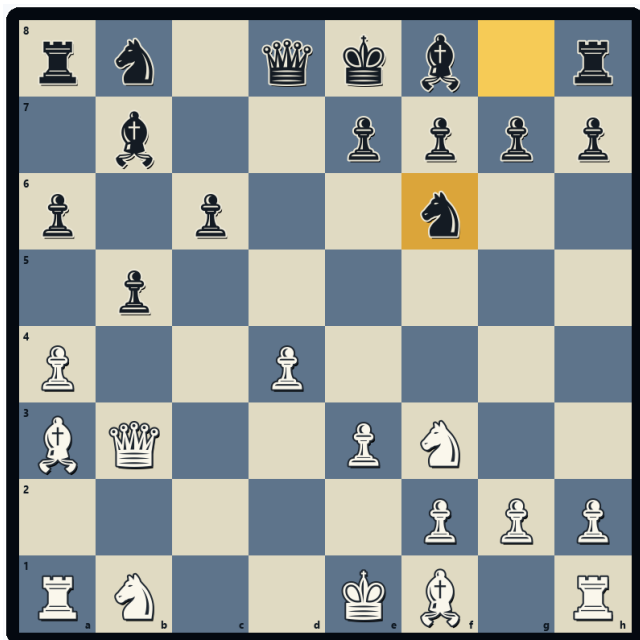
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against early Bf5, cxd5 and Qb3 turn development time into structural pressure.

30. Slav Early dxc4 Pawn Hold



06 - Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

Black takes c4 before developing the knight and supports it with b5; White attacks the pawn chain with a4 and b3.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use a4 and b3 to break the queenside chain.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...b5: Black tries to preserve the extra pawn.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 dxc4 4. e3 b5 5. a4 Bb7 6. b3 cxb3 7. Qxb3 a6 8. Ba3 Nf6

MEMORY RULE

Early Slav pawn hold: a4 attacks b5, b3 attacks c4, development finishes the job.

30. Decision Framework

Slav Early dxc4 Pawn Hold

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black takes c4 before developing the knight and supports it with b5; White attacks the pawn chain with a4 and b3.
PIECE JOB	White's queen, bishop and a-pawn work together against the b5-c4 chain while development continues.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not expect a4 alone to recover the pawn.
TRADE FILTER	Do not exchange the light bishop if it is the cleanest piece for recovering c4 and attacking the weakened diagonal.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Undermine the queenside chain, regain the pawn with development, then use Black's weakened squares rather than hunting material. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not expect a4 alone to recover the pawn.

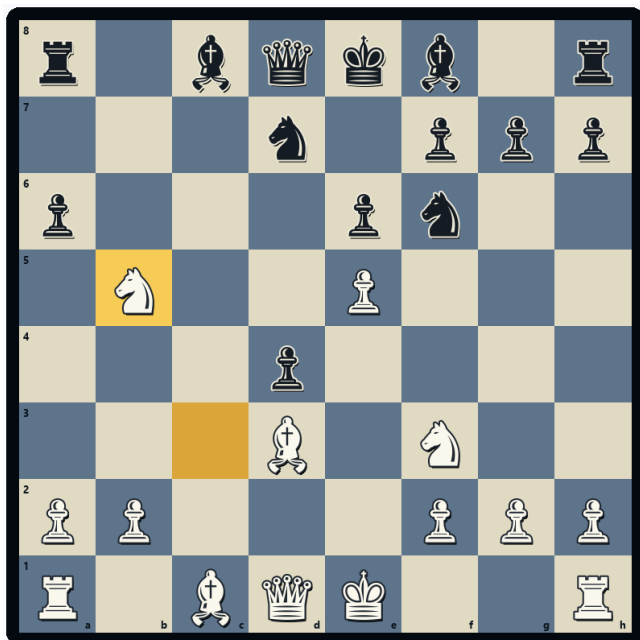
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Early Slav pawn hold: a4 attacks b5, b3 attacks c4, development finishes the job.

31. Meran Main Line



07 - Semi-Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use the development lead to gain central space.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...b5: Black gains time on the bishop and frees Bb7.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6 9. e4 c5 10. e5 cxd4 11. Nxb5

MEMORY RULE

Meran: Black frees the bishop with b5; White answers with e4-e5 and speed.

31. Decision Framework

Meran Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	The Meran releases Black's light bishop with b5 and Bb7, while White builds e4-e5 and accepts a forcing central battle.
PIECE JOB	White's bishops and central pawns become powerful only if the king is ready for the center to open.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not sacrifice on b5 without calculating the exact center.
TRADE FILTER	Keep attacking pieces while the center is open, but trade a defender when that makes the e5 advance or kingside attack concrete.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the central expansion to open lines, then shift from pawn play to piece play before Black consolidates. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not sacrifice on b5 without calculating the exact center.

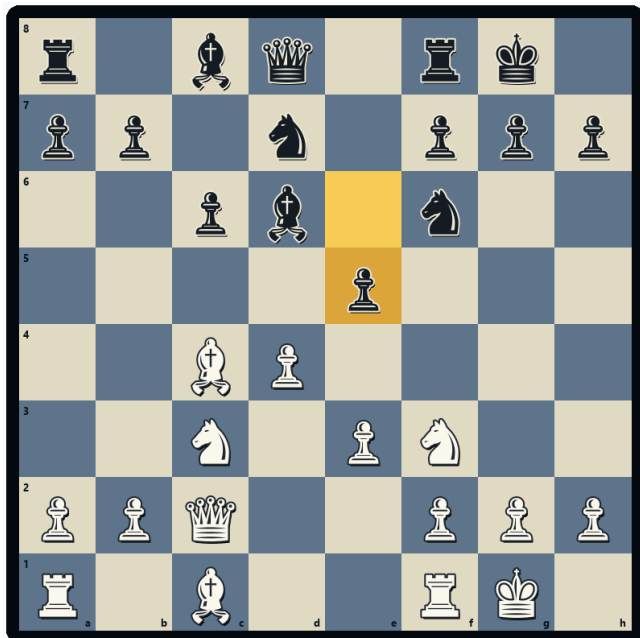
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Meran: Black frees the bishop with b5; White answers with e4-e5 and speed.

32. Anti-Meran with Qc2



07 - Semi-Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Qc2, Bd3, and O-O to support central expansion.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bd6: Black develops toward h2 and prepares castling.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

MEMORY RULE

Qc2 Anti-Meran: support e4, castle, and make Black reveal the center first.

32. Decision Framework

Anti-Meran with Qc2

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Qc2 supports e4, protects h7 pressure, and delays the bishop commitment so White can meet Meran ideas with more flexibility.
PIECE JOB	Qc2 supports e4 and keeps the bishop flexible, but White must finish development before treating the queen move as an attack.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push the center when Black can strike it immediately.
TRADE FILTER	Trade central pawns when the resulting open files favor White's developed pieces; avoid exchanges that solve Black's space problem.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Castle, coordinate rooks and use the queen's support of e4 to claim the center at the right moment. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push the center when Black can strike it immediately.

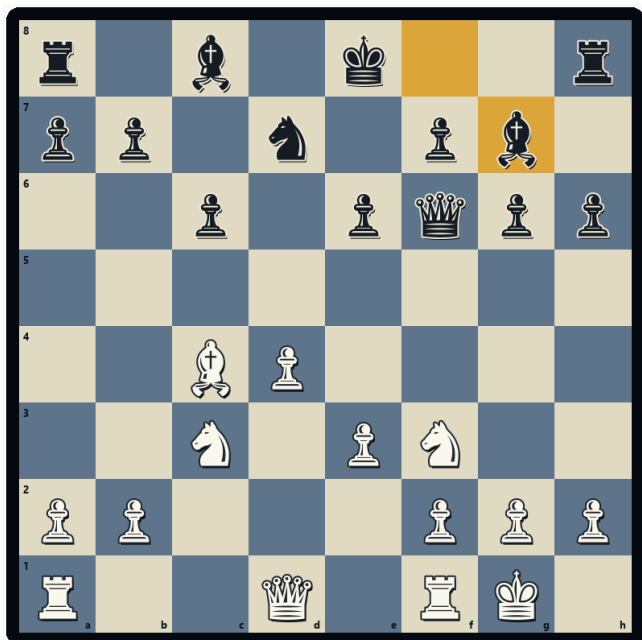
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Qc2 Anti-Meran: support e4, castle, and make Black reveal the center first.

33. Moscow Variation



07 - Semi-Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bd3, O-O, and Ne4 against the exposed queen.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Qxf6: Black keeps a sound structure and the bishop pair.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

MEMORY RULE

Moscow: trade the bishop, gain time on Qf6, use development before the bishop pair matters.

33. Decision Framework

Moscow Variation

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White exchanges on f6, giving Black the bishop pair but avoiding the sharpest Anti-Moscow and Botvinnik complications.
PIECE JOB	Bxf6 reduces Black's kingside activity, but White must use the time to complete development and challenge the center.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not move the same piece repeatedly just to attack Qf6.
TRADE FILTER	Trading the g5-bishop for the f6-knight is justified by reduced counterplay and tempo, not by a universal bishop-for-knight rule.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Develop Bd3, castle and use the calmer position to apply pressure before Black's bishops become fully active. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not move the same piece repeatedly just to attack Qf6.

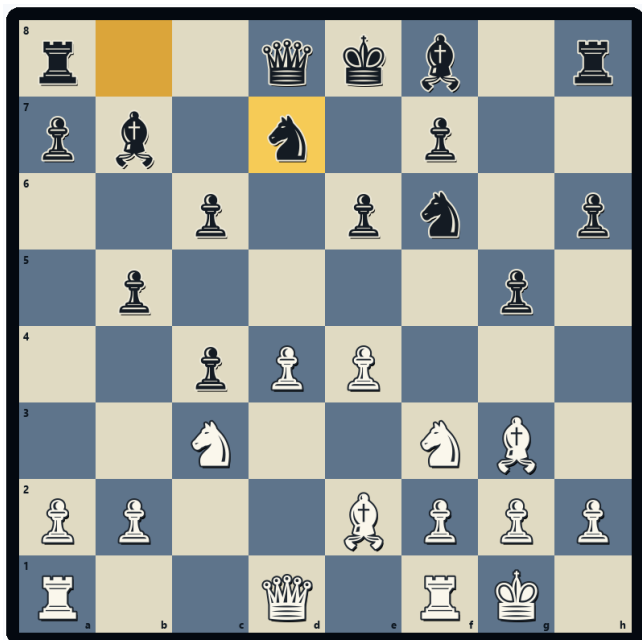
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Moscow: trade the bishop, gain time on Qf6, use development before the bishop pair matters.

34. Anti-Moscow Gambit



07 - Semi-Slav Defense

READ THE POSITION

White preserves the bishop with Bh4 and builds e4, entering a sharp gambit where development and central force matter more than immediate pawn recovery.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Be2, O-O, and Qc2 before recovering material.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...g5: Black gains the bishop pair and kingside space at structural cost.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bh4 dxc4 7. e4 g5 8. Bg3 b5 9. Be2 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Anti-Moscow: preserve the bishop, build e4, castle, then use Black's loosened king.

34. Decision Framework

Anti-Moscow Gambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White preserves the bishop with Bh4 and builds e4, entering a sharp gambit where development and central force matter more than immediate pawn recovery.
PIECE JOB	White's center and active bishops compensate for the pawn only if development remains faster than Black's consolidation.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not spend tempi chasing c4 while Black's king is vulnerable.
TRADE FILTER	Avoid exchanging attacking pieces unless the trade wins back material or leaves a lasting structural gain.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Castle, activate rooks and convert the development lead into open lines before attempting to recover every pawn. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not spend tempi chasing c4 while Black's king is vulnerable.

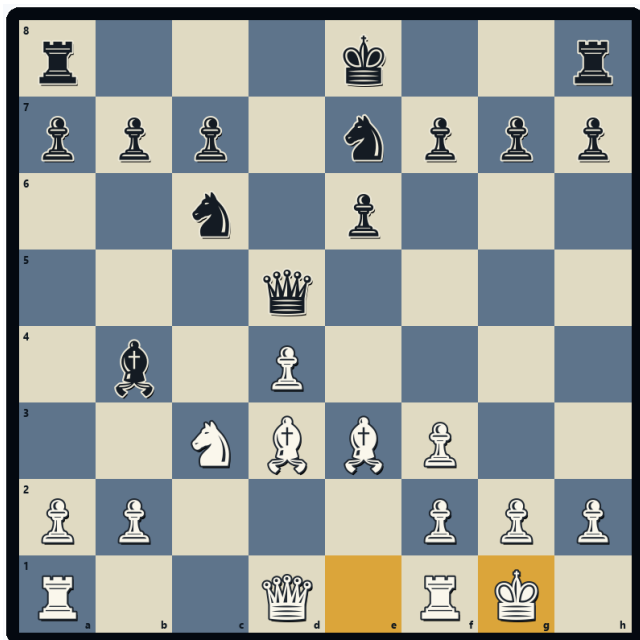
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Anti-Moscow: preserve the bishop, build e4, castle, then use Black's loosened king.

35. Chigorin Defense



08 - Queen's Gambit Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Be3 and Nc3 to attack the queen naturally.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bg4: Black pins f3 and prepares active exchanges.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. exf3 Qxd5 6. Be3 e6 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd3 Nge7 9. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Against the Chigorin, exchange d5 and develop with tempo against the queen.

35. Decision Framework

Chigorin Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.
PIECE JOB	The doubled f-pawns give White open lines and bishop activity, so pieces should use those assets rather than defend appearances.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not reject exf3 automatically; open files can compensate.
TRADE FILTER	Trade Black's active minor pieces when the bishop pair and open files remain; avoid exchanges that leave only the doubled pawns.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use bishops and open files to create threats, then simplify only after Black's activity has been neutralized. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not reject exf3 automatically; open files can compensate.

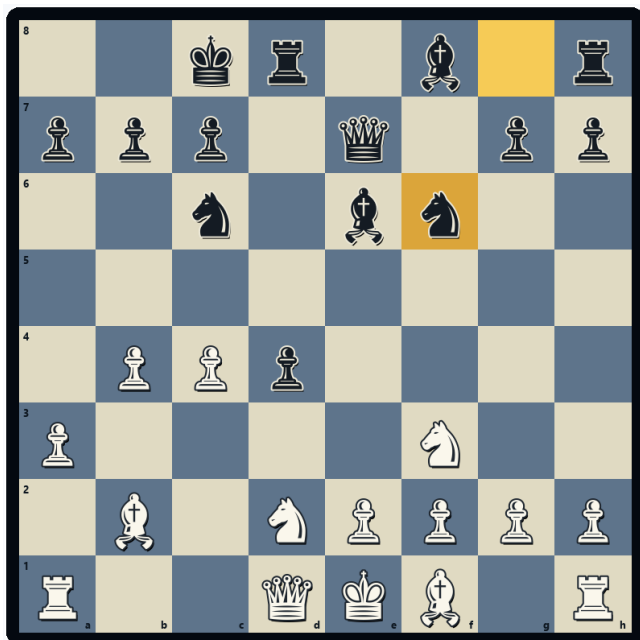
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the Chigorin, exchange d5 and develop with tempo against the queen.

36. Albin Countergambit



08 - Queen's Gambit Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nf3, Nbd2, and b4 to contain d4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...d4: Black gains space and restricts c3 and e3.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O-O 8. Bb2 f6 9. exf6 Nxf6

MEMORY RULE

Albin: blockade d4, complete development, and return the pawn if it kills the initiative.

36. Decision Framework

Albin Countergambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.
PIECE JOB	White's knights blockade d4 while the bishops develop around the advanced pawn without grabbing it prematurely.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not grab the advanced pawn while underdeveloped.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange the dangerous attacking pieces before collecting the pawn, especially when Black's queen and bishops point at the king.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Complete development, blockade the wedge, remove tactical attackers, and only then convert the extra central pawn. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not grab the advanced pawn while underdeveloped.

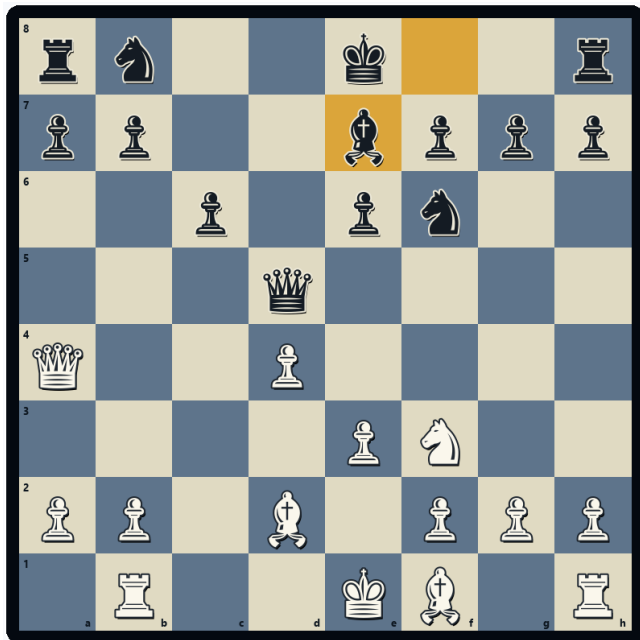
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Albin: blockade d4, complete development, and return the pawn if it kills the initiative.

37. Baltic Defense



08 - Queen's Gambit Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nf3, Bd2, and e3 against the queen.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bxb1: Black gives the bishop for a rook-tempo sequence.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Qa4+ c6 5. Rxb1 Qxd5 6. Nf3 e6 7. Bd2 Nf6 8. e3 Be7

MEMORY RULE

Baltic move order: cxd5, Qa4+, Rxb1-check before recapture.

37. Decision Framework

Baltic Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.
PIECE JOB	Qa4+ and the active bishops exploit Black's early bishop move while White develops with threats.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not recapture before inserting Qa4+.
TRADE FILTER	Trade queens only when White's development or structural edge survives; otherwise keep the initiative against the exposed king.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the gained tempos to mobilize every piece, then turn the lead into central pressure rather than chasing the bishop. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not recapture before inserting Qa4+.

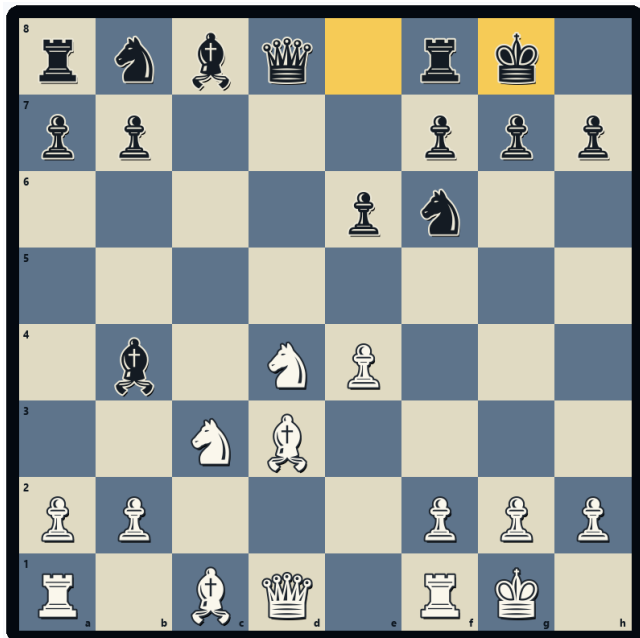
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Baltic move order: cxd5, Qa4+, Rxb1-check before recapture.

38. Marshall Defense



08 - Queen's Gambit Sidelines

READ THE POSITION

Black plays Nf6 before supporting d5; White exchanges and gains central space by driving the knight with e4.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nc3, Bd3, and castling behind the center.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nxd5: Black recovers the pawn with a knight but loses time.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nf6 3. cxd5 Nxd5 4. Nf3 e6 5. e4 Nf6 6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd3 c5 8. O-O cxd4 9. Nxd4 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Marshall: exchange d5, play e4, and turn the knight's lost time into development.

38. Decision Framework

Marshall Defense

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black plays Nf6 before supporting d5; White exchanges and gains central space by driving the knight with e4.
PIECE JOB	White's central pawns and rapidly developed pieces should make the black knight's repeated moves visible on the board.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not keep attacking the knight if development is stronger.
TRADE FILTER	Keep active central pieces and exchange only when the resulting space or pawn gain remains after queens come off.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Build the center with tempo, castle and open lines before Black catches up in development. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not keep attacking the knight if development is stronger.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Marshall: exchange d5, play e4, and turn the knight's lost time into development.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.